NEHA RATHORE, NAYSAYER

UP mein ka ba?
Khatam rozigar ba
Mantri ke bitwa
badi rangatdaar ba
Kisaanan ke chhati pe
rondat motorcar ba
Corona se lakhan
mar gayile
Laashan se Ganga
bhar gayile
Kafan nochat kukur
bilaar ba
ae baba, UP
mein ka ba?



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

biggest Bhojpuri stars of all time—first put out a hip-hop style video aggrandising the Yogi regime's achievements. With the sound of conch shells, visuals of 'development' and Hindu motifs laid on thick, he intoned in his thick, breathy voice: '*UP Mein Sab Ba* (Uttar Pradesh has everything)'. Hours later, Bihar-based folk singer Neha Rathore issued a stinging riposte—parodying Ravi Kishan's words, referencing Hathras, Lakhimpur Kheri and last year's Covid deaths, and asking tauntingly, '*UP Mein Ka Ba* (What does UP have?)'. Actor-singer Dinesh Lal Yadav 'Nirahua' had set things off last September, with '*Aaenge Phir Yogi Hi*'. Last week, BJP MP Manoj Tiwari, also a Bhojpuri A-lister, put out '*Bhagwa Chadne Laga Hai*'. The Samajwadi side is busy too: ex-MLC Ashu Malik and his team have prepared at least five songs, and party worker-singer Chahat Malhotra too is in the game. For every reason, there's a rhyme.

GOA

A Broad Church

It's not usual to see the Catholic segment punching above its weight in Goa's elections—despite its 22 per cent share in a 1.7 million population—but the novelty of a four-cornered fight has made it a key factor for all. The Congress is banking on Michael Lobo and Alexio Reginald Lourenco in five constituencies. The BJP hopes Atanasio Monserrate, Nilesh Kabral, Mauvin Godinho and Tony Fernandes will sail its boat in eight. If TMC is betting big on Luizinho Faleiro, Churchill Alemao and Leander Paes, AAP is looking at Alina Saldanha to open its account. The outgoing assembly had 12 Catholic MLAs—one or two may make the difference between the gold and da Silva.

UTTAR PRADESH

A COUPLE OF ISSUES

A husband-wife squabble over Lucknow's Sarojini Nagar seat has the BJP in a spot. Sitting MLA-minister Swati Singh wants a renomination. Husband Daya Shankar, no pushover in the state BJP pecking order as its vice-chief, wants the seat too. The two have begun door-to-door campaigns within party circles. It's like some old parable: two hungry mouths and just one parantha that can't be split. Maybe a third candidate will run away with the raita.

PUNJAB

DEUCE!



PRABHJOT GILL

Congress bosses seem wary of favouring any of the warring factions in Punjab. So no ticket for the CM's brother Manohar Singh—he's now contesting as an independent from Bassi Pathania. Nor for kinsman Mohinder Kaypee, ex-PCC chief, who may join BJP. Another pet desire of **Charanjit Channi**—two tickets—has been nixed. He retained rights over Chamkaur Sahib, but didn't get to forage out in the Dalit-dominated Doaba region for an image-building second win. Channi's bete noire isn't getting a free ride either. Navjot Sidhu is dying for a CM face to be chosen—preferably himself! But the party wants the full triumvirate in balance: the Dalit, the Jat Sikh and Hindu face Sunil Jhakhar.

—with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Prashant Srivastava, Kaushik Deka and Kiran D. Tare